

The Future of Rest: A More-Than-Human Manifesto

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Abstract

Rest is a vital aspect of wakefulness. Technology has impacted our ability to rest through its colonisation of our attention, sleep, and recovery. Human-computer interaction researchers and designers have expressed the desire to contribute to human flourishing. However, design to support restful states remains largely tethered to human-centric paradigms. This paper identifies an oversight in human-computer interaction research and recognises rest as a more-than-human phenomenon that emerges through a dynamic interplay of multiple species, technologies, and ecosystems. We discuss this topic through the Daoist concepts of ‘Yin-Yang’ and ‘Wu-Wei’ as theoretical foundations for frameworks that reimagine the future of rest. We critically evaluate anthropocentric approaches to rest by reflecting on how embodied knowledge and practice can serve to bridge relational theories with practice. We propose a manifesto for ‘More-than-Human Yin-teraction’ that outlines design principles foregrounding rest as a dynamic and evolving ecology where regenerative states emerge through the entangled relations between human, nonhuman and natural systems.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI); HCI theory, concepts and models.**

Keywords

rest, human-computer interaction, entanglement, more-than-human, yin-yang, wu-wei, qigong, daoism

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1 Introduction

We, as a global community, face an unprecedented erosion of rest that is expressed as burnout [52], dysregulation¹, compounding effects on attention deficiency² and pressure on mental health³. The fracturing and *colonisation* of rest is a crisis that is intimately interwoven in large-scale global issues such as climate change [49], technological acceleration [40], and widespread psychological distress [72]. Some [83] have started referring to our present time as ‘the era of “work to death”’ or an ‘age of overwhelm’ [76]. It is no surprise that the phenomenon of ‘overworking’ is attributed to the blurring of boundaries between work and personal life, largely interwoven with dependency and interconnection through digital networks [83]. Since COVID-19, the World Health Organisation reports a 25% increase in the prevalence of anxiety and depression worldwide⁴. This rising tide of psychological distress feeds into and is fed by a consumerist culture that promises relief through an endless array of products, apps, and productivity tools. However, these “solutions” often deepen our state of exhaustion and disconnection, creating a self-perpetuating cycle where burnout drives consumption, which in turn intensifies the very conditions it claims to address. In our attempts to address these issues, we find ourselves caught in the paradox of seeking external fixes for what may fundamentally be a crisis of rest and regeneration –one that requires us to fundamentally reimagine our relationship with technology, work, and wellbeing.

The pervasive influence of consumerist culture propels an urge to cure psychological distress within a relentless machinery of capitalist discourse. Vanheule et al. [77] observes that we are caught in an endless pursuit of fetishised objects such as digital devices, wellness apps, or productivity tools. While these technologies promise relief from existential discontent, in this paper we will explore how they actually tighten our state of corporeal tension.

As our world grows increasingly interconnected through technology, we find ourselves living a paradox of deepening disconnection [74] from the regenerative rhythms that sustain both human and nonhuman life. The advent of the electric light bulb marked not just a technological shift, but the beginning of a systematic hijacking of rest [22] and its incorporation into capitalist logic, where even

¹ *Oversensitive and overreactive: what is nervous system dysregulation and how can it be resolved?*, <https://www.theguardian.com/wellness/2024/mar/04/what-is-nervous-system-dysregulation>, Accessed 2024-12-03

² *The Lost Skill of Resting With ADHD*, <https://www.verywellmind.com/the-lost-skill-of-resting-with-adhd-6755072>, Accessed 2024-12-03

³ *Rethinking Rest Guide*, <https://www.mentalhealth.org.uk/our-work/programmes/families-children-and-young-people/resources/rethinking-rest-guide>, Accessed 2024-12-03

⁴ <https://www.who.int/news/item/02-03-2022-covid-19-pandemic-triggers-25-increase-in-prevalence-of-anxiety-and-depression-worldwide>, Accessed 2024-11-30

sleep has become a productivity metric to be optimised. The modification of rest itself transforms restoration into yet another object of desire that is perpetually out of reach. This has intensified through digital technologies that promise connection while often fostering states of perpetual alertness and ecological disruption.

“Something seems to be deeply amiss in what we imagine our tools are for.” [8, p.6] This paper acknowledges a shift in human-computer interaction (HCI) towards a *more-than-human motivation* in regard to ‘human flourishing’ [43, 46, 56, 61]. From this perspective, human flourishing is often viewed as an entangled and relational process across ecologies and systems that decentre the human across a fabric of experience. In this paper, we contribute to the dialogue of this paradigm shift through the form of a manifesto translating experiential qualities from Daoist philosophy by presenting considerations for the design of the ‘future of rest’. We propose a lens inspired by Daoist philosophy and practice to re-frame and respond to the relentless drive towards productivity and perpetual doing.

Rather than adding more solutions or calls-to-action, we proposed turning inward to explore how cultivating internal balance through principles like *Yin-Yang* and *Wu-Wei* that might inform a more harmonious relationship with technology—one that honours cycles of rest and regeneration as essential to true flourishing, not just for humans but for the broader ecology of beings and systems with which we are inextricably entangled. We do so to spark dialogue in the HCI community around the vital importance of taking a more-than-human perspective on designing for rest. We critically reflect on current approaches for ‘rest-centred’ HCI and use the model of a manifesto to respond by articulating our principles and goals [3] and propose a new way of thinking [24] in this area.

We highlight the merit of existing frameworks like slow design [69] and the slow professor movement [6] attempting to address the challenges of the pace of technological development and associated stress and dysfunction. However, we contend that anthropocentric approaches often inadvertently reinforce the very productivity paradigms they seek to challenge. We identify a gap in HCI research and the opportunity to view rest as a more-than-human phenomenon encompassing intricate webs of biological, technological, and ecological rhythms. We make a case for approaching rest from the perspective of cultivating balance that is guided by the theories of *Yin-Yang* and *Wu-Wei* from Daoist philosophy. We present a manifesto, “More-than-Human Yin-teraction” (MoTH Yin), as a paradigm that reimagines rest not merely as a wellness imperative but as a fundamental force of planetary regeneration. We conclude by articulating our vision of how our manifesto for MoTH Yin can be enacted in design and HCI.

2 Daoist Philosophy and Practice

2.1 Dao

The *Dao De Jing*, also spelled ‘*Tao Te Ching*’, or ‘Classic of the Way and Virtue’ by Laozi (also spelled Lao Tzu), is a profound seminal Daoist text from Chinese philosophy. It is a collection of eighty-one verses that expound a methodology for living in harmony with the *Dao* (*Tao*). The *Dao* is referred to as an underlying, ineffable principle that governs the universe and all of existence. The *Dao* is beyond description, transcending language and concepts, yet it can

be understood through simplicity, humility, and alignment with a natural order. [84] The profundity of the *Dao De Jing* lies not only in its message but in its methodology. *Dao* has extraordinary depth and meaning in Chinese philosophy. It is often translated as ‘the way’ or ‘the Way’. It is a fundamental term in Chinese philosophy that designates the essence of all things that encompasses ultimate reality, truth, method. The term implies a human aspect within the way, as in the road must ‘be walked’ by someone. [9] In this paper, we argue that concepts from the *Dao De Jing* can offer ways of reframing designing for rest as a dynamic process that highlights the vital aspect of embodiment in application. By articulating our manifesto, we maintain the role of designers and researchers in adopting or creating modes of cultivation to practice tuning into our own cycles of rest to develop full and rich understandings of *Yin-Yang* and *Wu-Wei* to enact in HCI practice.

In this paper, we have used an English translation of the *Dao De Jing* written from the perspective of an expert practitioner of more than thirty years in the Chinese arts [84]. We did so to foreground an embodied understanding of the concepts and teachings of the text. We have included verses from the text to illuminate theory and add richness to presentation of the Daoist concepts. Mitchell [53] states, “All writings are... catalysts rather than absolutes...” and “any text is only ever a snapshot in time” [p.15]. This snapshot evolves with personal understanding that is shaped through personal cultivation and practice. The first and second authors of this paper have extensive training in a range of somatic movement practices, including martial arts, internal arts, trance, contemporary movement and dance practices. Adding to this, the first and second authors work in practice-based interdisciplinary research that bridges Eastern philosophy with HCI and Western psychology, respectively. Moreover, we have chosen Mitchell’s translation of the *Dao De Jing* [84] to emphasise our research values as researcher-practitioners by using a translator-practitioner perspective that has been refined through long-standing experiential enquiry.

The highest De⁵ is expressed naturally since it follows the way of the Dao.

Dao is an entity both vague and elusive.

Though vague and elusive, it contains form.

In the midst of its dark obscurity, it contains the Jing⁶.

When rarefied, the Jing contains the truth; since the times of old, its power has not depleted. It contains the potential for understanding the origin of all. How do we find the origin?

By understanding this.

[84, Verse 21–Emptiness of the Heart]

2.2 Qi, Yin-Yang and Wu-Wei

Somatic practices support refining perception and attention [80], and a practitioner builds expertise through repatterning habitual

⁵*De* is the result of a step-by-step process of cultivation that enables the mind to begin to perceive (and thus act) in an upright and virtuous manner. Thus, we often translate the term as meaning ‘virtue’. It is a naturally expressed quality of the mind rather than a contrived set of morals that we apply to ourselves.” [84, p.181]

⁶From the perspective of the practitioner, *Jing* is often referred to as one of the ‘three treasures’ that are ‘one and the same’ as with *Qi* and *Shen*. *Jing* is translated as ‘essence’. It relates to growth, reproduction and longevity. [15, 53]

cognitive flows [81]. This can offer a graduated approach to developing a sensibility of the body and mind. *Qi* is an energetic substance that is often translated as “vital energy” and central to the practice Taijiquan (Tai Chi) and *Qi-gong* [4]. *Qi-gong*, is a somatic practice and a form of energetic training that explicitly works with ‘*Qi*’ to harmonise *Yin-Yang*. Lee et al. [41] describes the use of *Qi* for the development of physical balance through posture, breathing, movement and stabilising and applying attention. Research has shown that *Qi-gong* has multiple beneficial effects on the body and mind such as, enhancing alpha brain wave activity and increasing the levels of beta-endorphins –hormones that play a key role in regulating pain and pleasure in the body–while reducing psychological issues including depression, anxiety, and hostile feelings [41]. Evidence from research has also shown that *Qi-gong* can create meaningful improvements across psychological, hormonal, and immune system functioning. Practices like *Qi-gong* do not require perfect focus on the space of natural vacuity yet allow one to work towards it. It has been described as ‘working in’ as opposed to ‘working out’.⁷ In this way, practitioners work with the body and mind to process, listen, and develop sensitivity to somatic objects, and in doing so gradually cultivate an embodied understanding of harmony and attunement that internally resolves outwardly apparent contradictions or paradoxes over time.

An example of a contradiction or dialectical interactive framework and process is that of *Yin* and *Yang*. According to *Yin-Yang* theory, all universal phenomena are shaped by the integration of two opposite cosmic energies, namely *Yin* and *Yang*. In Chinese philosophy, the process of change is described as a dialectical interaction of *Yin* and *Yang* [14]. This dialectical interplay manifests not merely as abstract philosophy but as embodied wisdom encoded in the very fabric of existence, exemplified in the excerpt from Verse 22, of the *Dao De Jing*, below. The *Dao De Jing* captures this paradoxical wisdom through a series of inversions that illuminate the generative power of apparent negation: wholeness emerging from partiality, straightness from crookedness, fullness from emptiness, rebirth from death [75]. When *Yin* reaches its apex, it naturally transforms into *Yang* –a principle that explains how deep rest catalyses the emergence of vitality⁸, creativity, and renewed energy [10].

These reversals point to a profound understanding of rest not as mere absence but as a generative void from which all manifestation emerges. This dynamic challenges the contemporary imperative of perpetual productivity, which often drives individuals to exhaust their *Yang* energies through relentless activity. Such perpetual activation, driven by what we might term the ‘achievement imperative’ [39, 50] of digital capitalism, disrupts the natural oscillation between rest and activity. The resulting imbalance manifests in widespread phenomena like chronic fatigue and burnout, symptoms of a broader ecological crisis in which human rhythms have become desynchronised from natural cycles. Daoist philosophy suggests that the dynamic alternation between *Yin* and *Yang* is a correct method for maintaining true wellbeing.

Thus, establishing a paradigm where rest serves not as mere cessation but as the generative ground from which all activity

emerges. This understanding presents the primacy of *Yin* over *Yang*, highlighted in the excerpt below, that we argue is particularly emphasised in Verses 21-29 of the *Dao De Jing*. This offers a radical reframing of rest that transcends contemporary binary oppositions between activity and passivity, suggesting instead a dynamic interplay where conscious resting becomes the source of regenerative potential. This principle suggests that the beholder of attention must find repose in a space prior to mental formation –a domain of pure potentiality that the text identifies as *Yin*. This *Yin* realm, far from being an empty void, represents what the *Dao De Jing* describes as a space that, “although vague and elusive, contains potential for manifestation” [84].

*Become pliable to be made whole,
Become crooked to become straight.
Become empty, and you will thus be filled.
Become tattered, so you may become renewed.
Have little, and you will gain much.
Those with plenty live in confusion.*
[84, Verse 22–Increasing Pliability]

Central to the embodied methodology of the *Dao De Jing* is the concept of *Wu-Wei*, literally translated as ‘in the absence of [or] without doing’ [66, p.299]. A hallmark of *Qigong* is not focusing on sensations, but rather engaging in a practice of letting go of mental doing, involvement of nerves, and stepping back from the senses. The vital point is that one ‘achieves’ harmony and wellbeing through rest. This can be thought of as an action, yet without doing–*Wu-Wei*. In this paper, *Wu-Wei* is understood as an emergence of inner and outer harmony, a generative force of conscious rest. Slingerland [66] states that *Wu-Wei* “describes a state of personal harmony in which actions flow freely and instantly from one’s spontaneous inclinations without the need for extended deliberation or inner struggle and yet nonetheless perfectly accord with the dictates of the situation at hand, displaying an almost supernatural efficiency” [p.300]. However, textual analysis and commentary are no substitute for personal embodied practice over a protracted period of time—a turning inwards and nourishing stillness, becomes a cause for insight to arise [73].

3 Related Work

3.1 Relational Theories

In this paper, we acknowledge and draw on relational theories that have emerged more prominently in transdisciplinary research in HCI. Relational theory approaches represent a significant shift from traditional user-centred paradigms towards frameworks that recognise the deeply interconnected nature of human-nonhuman relationships. Research areas such as Entanglement HCI [16], life-centred design [7, 71] Human-Computer Intra-Action [29], relational performative meaning making [19] have emerged as a turn away from user centrality and argue for horizontal [21] and diffractive [18, 20] approaches to understanding and meaning making.

These approaches build on a new materialist understanding of agency emerging through material interactions rather than being solely human-driven. The concept of entanglement, central to these frameworks, describes how humans and technologies co-evolve and shape each other through their interactions. The idea of body-thing [25] disrupts the idea of the body as purely biological and fixed

⁷ *Qi-gong, what can it do for you?* https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hgAmJmVeo5A&ab_channel=PaulChek, Accessed 2024-12-03

⁸ *The Power of Deep Rest*, <https://magazine.ucsf.edu/power-deep-rest>, Accessed 2024-12-02

and reflects a commitment to understand the bodies in the world as related and interconnected. In this world, it does not make sense to juxtapose humans and nonhumans or try to make them appear the same; rather, we can seek more-than-human possibilities to derive meaning [20]. This connects closely with Barad's notion of intra-action [5], which suggests that entities do not pre-exist their relationships but emerge through them. These theoretical foundations are grounded in embodied approaches that recognise how our physical, lived experience fundamentally shapes our engagement with technology.

Enactivism [12, 78], developed by Francisco Varela, Evan Thompson, and Eleanor Rosch, presents a framework for understanding cognition as a dynamic, embodied, and relational process. Varela et al. argues that consciousness and cognition emerge from the active interaction between an organism and its environment through bodily engagement with the world. This is grounded in the biological concept of 'autopoiesis', where living systems maintain themselves by continuously generating and regenerating their own components, making cognition fundamental to survival and autonomy. This leads to a principle of mutual co-determination, where organisms and environments are inseparable and continuously shape each other through their ongoing relational dynamic.

Building on Maturana and Varela's work around autopoiesis [51], Haraway [26] proposes the concept 'sympoiesis' to denote 'making with'. Sympoiesis as a term, that unfolds autopoiesis and generatively unfurls and extends it [26]. Sympoiesis views all living things as made through relationships and interconnections with others—entities do not exist in isolation. The process involves complex, dynamic, responsive, and historically situated systems of collaboration and co-creation. It goes beyond just cooperation between separate entities, relying on the participants to actively shape and constitute each other through their interactions.

3.2 Rest in HCI

In HCI, rest is understood as a vital aspect of wellbeing, encompassing both physical and mental recovery and regeneration. Previous work has responded to rest by addressing a need to reduce physical strain, such as repetitive stress or eye fatigue [2, 13], through ergonomic solutions [28] and break reminders [38, 45, 65], while also supporting cognitive recovery from mental fatigue caused by constant multitasking or information overload [60]. Adding to this, popular books such as Cal Newport's 'Deep Work' [55] and Johann Hari's 'Stolen Focus' [27] explore how modern distractions undermine our ability to concentrate deeply and achieve meaningful work. While Deep Work focuses on cultivating intentional practices to reclaim focus and produce high-value work in a distracted world, Stolen Focus takes a broader societal view, examining how systemic factors, such as digital technology, social media, and information overload can erode attention on a collective level. Together, these books highlight the urgent need to address both personal habits and societal structures to protect and enhance our capacity to focus our attention. We argue that embodied qualities addressed through *Yin-Yang* and *Wu-Wei* foster the cultivation of attention stabilisation and self-awareness that are integral in contributing to regenerative states, or learning how to deeply rest, in the body and mind, despite external conditions.

Increasingly in interface design, there are examples of rest is a design principle, such as, focus or dark modes, or tools that encourage users to step away from screens. Applications that promote mindfulness, such as guided meditations or stress management tools, integrate rest into everyday technology use. Similarly, wearable devices and ambient systems track stress and recovery, helping individuals prioritise rest based on personal metrics. These innovations aim to balance productivity with rest, recognising the importance of boundaries, such as digital detox features or do-not-disturb modes, that help manage work-life balance and prevent burnout.

However, designing for rest poses challenges, as technology often prioritises engagement over restful experiences, making it difficult for users to disengage. Individual needs for rest vary widely, depending on cultural and personal factors, complicating universal design approaches. The paradox of technology further complicates this effort: while tools can support rest, they can also lead to overuse and dependency [17, 47]. Emerging research explores concepts like slow technology [6] that argues for reflective and meaningful interactions over speed and efficiency and immersive technologies that promote rest in subtle ways [11, 64]. The challenge for HCI, is to design systems that enable genuine restful interactions while mitigating the overstimulation and dependency often associated with digital environments.

4 A Paradox of Design for Rest

Current approaches to designing for rest expose a fundamental paradox where they often reinforce the very productivity paradigms and consumerist mindsets they aim to challenge. Applications, devices, and systems marketed as solutions for rest frequently transform restoration itself into yet another object of desire and achievement, perpetuating cycles of striving and dissatisfaction rather than enabling genuine repose. In contrast to this, Daoism values simplicity, non-interference and spontaneity, encouraging individuals to align with the *Dao*, or the natural way of things, which involves embracing stillness and non-striving rather than attempting to control or achieve rest through external tools or systems.

The Dao of Heaven does not contend with anything and thus it conquers.

It does not speak, and yet it is adequately answered.

It does not beckon things to it, and yet it is supplied with all its needs.

Though it appears to be apathetic, it has well laid out plans.

Heaven's net is cast widely; though its holes are large, nothing slips through.

[84, Verse 73—Acting with Responsibility]

This is why the sage practices Wu-Wei and teaches that which is unspoken.

The myriad beings exist around him, and yet he does not become involved.

He assists in their development and yet remains apart. He carries out his work with governance, finishes his actions and then forgets them.

He remains apart, and thus suffers no loss.

[84, Verse 2—Nourishing Self]

Daoism also teaches that rest is not merely the absence of activity but is a state of balance and harmony with the world, including the self, others, and the environment. This aligns with the idea of relational body mapping [20] and new feminism [5], which also look to the “spaces in between”—the interstitial moments where bodies, thoughts, and technologies intersect and where rest and relaxation can emerge naturally without being commodified. The Daoist view would suggest that instead of striving for rest as a goal to be achieved, the focus should be on returning to one’s natural state of balance or creating conditions for bodily alignment allowing rest to emerge organically when one is in harmony with their environment and with themselves, without needing to turn it into a consumerist pursuit.

The technology landscape treats rest as a commodity to be optimised, tracked, and gamified⁹. “In today’s world, relaxation and happiness are luxury goods”.¹⁰ Sleep apps quantify our repose, meditation timers measure our stillness, and wellness platforms award badges for relaxation achievements. Commodifying rest transforms what should be a natural, regenerative process into another metric of productivity, another goal to strive for, another area where we must improve and optimise ourselves. The irony is clear: by attempting to support rest, these technologies often generate new forms of anxiety and inadequacy.

A fundamental shift is needed that moves beyond individualistic, human-centred approaches to rest. By applying *Yin-Yang* and *Wu-Wei* through a systems thinking lens, we can begin to understand rest as an emergent property of interconnected ecological, technological, and human systems. This perspective recognises that genuine rest cannot be achieved through isolated technological interventions but must emerge from balanced relationships across multiple scales and domains.

*Life is born from Dao and then nourished through De;
then it manifests within the realm of form.*

Life develops and evolves according to circumstance.

The myriad beings follow Dao and esteem De.

This is the natural way.

*The following of Dao and the esteeming De were not
mandated; this developed spontaneously.*

[84, Verse 51 –Birthing De]

In this reframing, the human body becomes not the central focus but rather one of many interfaces through which embodied knowledge gathering and meaning-making occur. Nevertheless, the body remains a site for sensing and cultivation. As expressed through soma design practitioners, it will be increasingly relevant for researchers to develop somatic sensibilities [44] in order to develop ourselves as sensing instruments attuning to the world. Conscious engagement through embodied practice fosters familiarising deeper awareness of the dynamic interplay between rest and activity across human and more-than-human domains. The body, by virtue of its decentred stance in more-than-human entanglement, serves as a natural bridge between new materialist understandings of agency emerging through material interactions and enactivist perspectives

on cognition, it arises as a co-determined dynamic unfolding process of organism-environment coupling.

*Let go of a sense of control to govern all under Heaven.
How do I know that this is so?*

*Because below Heaven, when we apply restrictions and
taboos,*

the people are increasingly poor.

*The more weapons of war are implemented,
the more the people of the country are troubled.*

*The more trickery used, the more contrivance there will
be.*

Thus, the sages say:

*Through Wu-Wei the people will be spontaneously trans-
formed.*

*The more we welcome stillness, the more the people will
be naturally righteous.*

*The less I interfere, the more the people will become
wealthy.*

The less desire I have, the closer to Pu¹¹ I become.

[84, Verse 57–Genuine Custom]

A systems-level application of *Yin-Yang* thinking transcends the false binary between technological engagement and rest. Instead of viewing technology as inherently disruptive to rest, this framework encourages us to explore how technological systems might be designed to support natural cycles of activity and repose across multiple scales, from cellular to social to ecological. The principle of *Wu-Wei* suggests that such support can emerge without force or control, rather through quietude, listening, and attunement to existing rhythms and relationships.

5 Beyond Anthropocentric Rest-centred design

The future of rest is deeply connected with care. Care is seen as condition for healing or repair [58]. We see that a key distinction of the Daoist lens in approaching more-than-human rest is an emphasis on embodiment and the view of moving through change from within. A process of getting to know oneself, actually embodying or ‘making with’ [26] through practice and sharing through application. The traditional human-centred approaches to rest in HCI have been instrumental in addressing individual wellbeing or self-care. However, in this paper, we argue that they are inherently limited by their anthropocentric focus. By expanding to a more-than-human motivation, we can be open to consider broader ecological and relational systems in which our technological solutions operate.

Tools like wearable devices, meditation apps, and screen-time reminders may help users rest, yet they have a narrow framing of rest as an individual experience and also neglect the interdependence of human and non-human systems. Furthermore, these approaches reflect an excess of *Yang* energy in their inclination to support active, controlling, and individually focused design principles, while potentially neglecting the *Yin* aspects of design, such as receptivity, integration, and collective restoration.

⁹*Self-Care is not a Commodity*, <https://www.theprojectheal.org/blog/self-care-commodity>, Accessed 2024-12-01

¹⁰*Relaxation sure is a luxury commodity*, <https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/opinion/just-in-jest/relaxation-sure-is-a-luxury-commodity/articleshow/107271374.cms?from=mdr>, Accessed 2024-12-01

¹¹*Pu* refers to a state of being likened to a log that has not been carved. It is a state that a Daoist practitioner aims to return to, before mental conditioning. It is commonly translated as ‘simplicity’.[84]

A more expansive, non-anthropocentric approach to rest in HCI redefines rest as a relational and ecological concept, encompassing the wellbeing of not just humans but also the environment, technologies, and nonhuman entities. In this view, rest extends to include the rest of ecosystems, such as the reduction of stress on natural resources or allowing ecosystems time to regenerate. For example, HCI could focus on designing systems that reduce energy consumption or minimise environmental harm, such as low-power devices, biodegradable materials, or software optimised for efficiency. We propose more-than-human rest could involve inspiration from restorative interactions [23] between humans and their environments or encourage users to step away from screens and engage with nature [79]. Or perhaps drawing inspiration from designing for women's health [37] and lunar cycles [67] or spiritually informed design [32, 34, 82] that acknowledges natural cycles or circadian rhythms [1, 35].

Beyond ecological considerations, non-anthropocentric rest in HCI could explore how technologies interact with non-human agents, such as animals or autonomous systems, to create harmonious shared spaces. For instance, smart environments might incorporate sensors and interfaces that consider the presence and needs of animals, enabling rest for both humans and non-human inhabitants of these spaces. Rest is already conceptualised for the technologies themselves—designing for systems to ‘rest’ during periods of inactivity to conserve energy and extend their lifecycle, reducing the strain on global resources. This is currently built into technology design, however, its motivation and integration are not made explicit in the communication of novel HCI research and design. A broader and explicit relational view of rest not only challenges the anthropocentric biases of traditional HCI but also fosters more sustainable and equitable systems thinking approaches.

6 More-Than-Human Yin-teraction (MoTH Yin)

In an age where technology has colonised not just human attention but the rest patterns of entire ecosystems, we declare rest as a multispecies revolution. The systematic erosion of deep rest, beginning with electric light and accelerating through digital technology, threatens not only human wellbeing but the regenerative cycles of Earth's living systems. Rest is not a human luxury but a vital force in the web of more-than-human life.

- **Harmony Through Entanglement and Dialectical Forces**

Like the Daoist principle of *Wu-Wei*, deep rest is both receptive and generative across species. Harmony and ecological flourishing emerge from true rest. Entanglement implies the practitioner taking responsibility to understand how to rest for themselves. Contributing to planetary regeneration through HCI springs from individual capacity to discover embodied relationships through dedicated training or practice.

- **Enhance Embodied Ecologies**

Technology must respect and enhance biological rhythms across species. Interfaces promote an awareness of more-than-human cycles. Design supports the integration of human, nonhuman, and ecological systems. Rest is understood as a planetary experience, not merely a human state.

- **Time is Multiple**

Reject anthropocentric time in favour of ecological cycles. Honour the rhythms of seasons, migrations, and planetary movements. Design for oscillation between activity and rest across species. Recognise that evolution and growth occur through periods of rest and activity.

- **Respect Ecological Boundaries**

Technology must respect planetary boundaries. Create spaces protected from technological disruption for all species. Design for preservation of natural dark and quiet. Support the right of all beings to undisturbed rest.

- **Rest as Resistance**

Deep rest challenges the extraction of planetary resources. Resting becomes a political act in an age of ecological and existential exhaustion. Design must support rest as a form of multispecies flourishing. We must strive to promote rest in the face of techno-capitalist acceleration.

7 Design Implications of MoTH Yin in Practice

Drawing from Daoist principles and the more-than-human perspectives emerging in HCI, we propose several key implications for design practice. These implications challenge conventional approaches that prioritise engagement and intervention, instead emphasising alignment with natural rhythms and careful attention to power relations in technological systems. We have advocated for design practices that support the principle of *Wu-Wei* rather than turning rest into another form of tracked engagement. Through our manifesto, MoTH Yin, we put forward the imperative for researchers and designers to more deeply consider why, how and what they design in more-than-human contexts that necessarily support natural cycles of activity and repose, rather than imposing artificial schedules or goals.

First, the application of MoTH Yin in practice will require not just new design methods but a fundamental shift in how we conceptualise and support rest. MoTH Yin articulates a bridge between relational theory [25] and the Daoist principles and embodied understandings of *Yin-Yang* and *Wu-Wei*. Importantly, we recognise that *Yin-Yang* and *Wu-Wei* cannot be fully grasped through theoretical analysis alone; their understanding implies taking responsibility as designers and design researchers [42] through embodied exploration to develop a richness in understanding through direct practice and personal cultivation. This offers opportunities for participatory approaches to explore how to develop design research instruments, models and frameworks that consider the *Yin-Yang* of contexts, methods and solutions.

We must recognise that designing for rest is fundamentally an act of establishing new power relations, not just between humans and technology but across entire ecosystems. As Bridle [8] argues, we need to move beyond anthropocentric intelligence towards planetary intelligence that recognises the interconnected nature of all beings. This requires “caring through” [59], entailing designing with awareness of how technological interventions ripple across temporal and ecological scales. If design and HCI are to be guided by *Wu-Wei*, practice will prioritise recovering and supporting natural rhythms rather than imposing artificial ones. This might mean creating systems that respond to and enhance existing ecological

patterns rather than disrupting them. This principle of alignment rather than intervention suggests shifting from designing for engagement to designing for resonance with natural cycles.

Central to MoTH Yin is a sense of agency to cultivate one's own embodied understanding of rest and balance. The cultivation of attention and using focusing and articulation by drawing on listening, somatic cultivation and contemplative practice are being increasingly used in HCI [30, 57, 63]. Soma design research argues for designers to develop somatic attunement and sensibility [44, 48], and the principles of MoTH Yin build on this. As Poikolainen Rosén et al.'s [62] work that focuses on *noticing* as a phenomenon through a longitudinal study. Our view aligns with this approach to understand how knowledge is situated, embodied and partial, a pluralistic rather than universal in posthuman epistemologies. We maintain that attuning and becoming aware of relationships and potential dialectic manifestations relies on developing and refining systematic embodied processes in HCI to engage with the world through the interface of the body.

Following the perspective of feminist care [36], we agree that designers must critically examine how their work affects power relations and self-transformation across human and non-human actors. This requires moving toward more-than-human symbiosis [31]. Through the logic of this paper, we propose that the goal is not to create more “rest technologies” but to foster conditions where regenerative rest can emerge naturally across species and systems. Through this lens, technology becomes not an instrument of control but a participant in the delicate dance of planetary rest and renewal.

HCI practitioners have established branches of research turning away from reifying the quantified self such as first-person practices that access the inner self [48]. Success in this context is measured not by engagement metrics but by the system's ability to support natural rhythms of rest and regeneration across scales. The practice of MoTH Yin requires a profound shift in how we evaluate success in rest-supporting technologies and new ways of evaluating systems that move away from engagement metrics are needed towards indicators that reflect system-wide balance. Only by moving beyond consumerist, human-centred approaches can we begin to design technologies that genuinely support rest as a vital force in planetary well-being by respecting ecological boundaries. A cultural exemplar of this motivation is the Balinese Festival, *Nyepi*, the Holy Day of Silence. Studies indicate that the *Nyepi* Day celebration leads to a decrease in greenhouse gas emissions due to a reduction in human activities, such as office work, transportation, and industrial operations. On this sacred day, the environment is free from human interference, resulting in improved air quality and healthier conditions. [70]

A more in-depth understanding of the *politics of rest* in practice, such as relationships and hierarchies and co-determined value setting, as outlined by [33], can help researchers to consider how rest can penetrate on many levels. In HCI, restoration and regeneration carry politics across genders, professions and contexts [54, 68]. Steinvorth observes the connection between self-care and rest, where rest emerges as “a tool for resistance”. “Resting, sleeping, and dreaming are thus recognised as deep sources for personal empowerment that had to be repressed in so far as individuals

and communities had to be controlled throughout the process of imperialism and colonialism that led to modernisation.” [68, p.167]

In this new paradigm, rest is understood as being *made with* [26], emerging through the entangled relations of human, technological, and ecological systems. In light of living in an era of unprecedented global challenges, one benefit is the welcoming of a plurality of worldviews that invites opportunities to authentically integrate knowledge from ancient wisdom traditions. MoTH Yin is thus presented not just as an academic framework, but as a living paradigm shift that reimagines rest beyond a wellness imperative into a fundamental force that can contribute to planetary regeneration. This approach urges HCI designers and researchers to develop their own experiential understanding of Daoist concepts elucidated in the *Dao De Jing*, allowing these ancient wisdom traditions to inform and transform contemporary technological practice.

The path forward is not about adding more features or solutions, but about learning to step back and allow dynamic balance to emerge across human and more-than-human systems. In this way, MoTH Yin opens a vital dialogue about how we might design for true flourishing in an age of ecological crisis—not through mastery or control, but through deep attention to the delicate dance of rest and renewal that sustains all life.

8 Vision

We envision a future where technology serves rather than subverts the rest patterns of our living systems. In this future, digital tools enhance rather than erode our capacity for inner clarity, care and planetary renewal. This paper has argued that rest is the foundation of ecological flourishing and evolutionary creativity. In this future, rest is not what happens when humans finish working; it is a generative force from which life and vitality emerge. The time has come to reclaim rest, not as an escape from technology, but as its highest purpose. The future of planetary wakefulness and wellbeing depends on our ability to integrate deep rest into the fabric of our technological world.

May we move forward with the wisdom of *Wu-Wei*, allowing action to emerge from deep attunement to the inner rhythms through body and mind to connect with those of more-than-human life. Together, we can create technologies that support rather than suppress the vital force of rest in all its forms.

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